

Photograph by MAHADEO SEN



FRIEND TO ALL:
Koda (centre)
mixes as easily
with Lalu (R) as
with Soren

ONE-MAN MAJORITY

The Government of Koda, an independent MLA, creates a record of sorts by completing a year

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

In mid-September 2006, when Madhu Koda gained power as the chief minister of Jharkhand, it appeared as if it was just another changeover—a consistent feature in Jharkhand's political firmament. After all, he was the fifth chief minister in six years of Jharkhand's existence and was leading a pack of independent legislators, known for their Machiavellian ambitions.

In fact, the beginning was no different as Koda secured only 41 votes while taking his first floor test in the 82-member Assembly with NDA staging a boycott. It was clearly a touch-and-go situation. But on the 18th of this September, the 36-year-old success-

fully completed one year in office as chief minister, creating a record of sorts for an independent MLA. So, is he a master strategist? Or, has he been plain lucky? The answer lies somewhere in between.

To begin with, Koda may have had to make compromises to achieve this milestone. There are many instances when he walked that extra mile to appease his bosses in Delhi. From a series of controversial appointments to going slow in high-profile criminal cases, Koda's calculated steps (*see box*) have paid off handsomely. These measures helped him win over UPA legislators and helped him enlist supporters like RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav, who prevented JMM chief Shibu Soren from emerging as a consensus

candidate for the top job.

Not surprisingly, Koda has been at his magnanimous best while allotting the posts of various boards and corporations to consensus candidates of his allies. The alliance partners, however, haven't submitted a list of candidates as they are yet to arrive at a consensus. "I believe in consensus," justifies Koda. "I speak to every alliance partner when it comes to taking decisions. Often, the process leads to a delay. This happens in coalition governments."

But arriving at a consensus is easier said than done. As chief minister, Koda has made many adversaries with "independent" ministers asking him to do the impossible for them. The Congress and RJD—which provide out-